

About the Examination

Recruiting body	Karnataka Public Service Commission (KPSC)
Post	Agricultural Officer (AO) / Asst. Agricultural Officer (AAO)
Paper 1	General Studies — 300 marks
Questions	~150 MCQs (4 options each)
Duration	2 hours (120 minutes)
Negative marking	-0.75 marks per wrong answer; 0 for unattempted
Exam date	26 July 2026
Paper 2	Agriculture subject paper (separate book)

Paper 1 — Eight Units

#	Chapter	Key Topics	Q
1	Current Affairs	Karnataka agri policy · Central schemes · International events · Appointments · Budget	33
2	General Science	Physics & Chemistry basics · Soil science · Irrigation water quality · Pesticide classification · Photoperiodism · Vaccines	33
3	Karnataka History & Geography	Ancient–Modern history · Agro-climatic zones · Soil classification · Rivers · Crops by region · Administrative structure	33
4	Indian Polity & Constitution	Fundamental rights · Panchayati Raj · Emergency provisions · RTI Act · Consumer Protection · Cooperative law · APMC Act	33
5	Rural Development & Schemes	PM-Kisan · PMFBY · RKVY · eNAM · FPOs · MSP mechanism · PMKSY · Jal Jeevan Mission · Karnataka state schemes	33
6	Mental Ability & Reasoning	Number/letter series · Analogy · Coding-decoding · Blood relations · Direction · Data interpretation (SAFE priority)	29
7	Science &	ISRO missions · Digital	33

	Technology	agriculture · Biotechnology · Nano-Urea/DAP · IPM pyramid · Protected cultivation · Seed classes	
8	Environment & Ecology	Western Ghats biodiversity · Environmental laws · International agreements · Agroforestry · JFM/VFC · NDRF/SDRF disaster norms	33

How to Use This Book

Each unit in this book follows a seven-section structure. Section 0 is a quick-reference snapshot of the chapter. Section 1 connects the topic to the Agricultural Officer's field role. Section 2 covers core concepts with Safe/Risky/Skip tags and practice notes. Section 3 is a high-yield facts table. Section 4 is the mind map placeholder for visual learners. Section 5 contains practice questions with answer explanations. Section 6 is a ten-item rapid revision extract. Section 7 lists references.

Recommended Study Schedule

Timeframe	What to Do
90 days to exam	Read Sections 0, 1, and 2 of each unit in order. Attempt all practice questions. Maintain a mistake log for questions where you selected the most attractive wrong answer.
30 days to exam	Revise Section 3 (Key Facts) and Section 6 (Rapid Revision) for all 8 units. Aim for 50+ MCQs daily across different units. Practise applying the Safe/Risky/Skip decision before reading the options.
One week to exam	Read Section 6 (Rapid Revision) every morning — all 80 facts in under 40 minutes. Review the mind map for chapters where recall is weakest. No new topics; consolidation only.
Night before exam	Read all 80 rapid revision facts once. Mark any that are unclear and revise that chapter's Section 3 briefly. Sleep by 10 PM.
In the exam hall	In the first 5 minutes, skim all questions and classify each: SAFE (attempt now), RISKY (attempt in round 2), or SKIP. Attempt all SAFE questions first. Return to RISKY only if time allows and certainty is above 80%. Never guess on SKIP questions.

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1.5 Practice Questions (33 MCQs)	
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Unit 2 — General Science

2.1 Physics · Chemistry · Biology · Nutrition · Health	
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Unit 3 — Karnataka History & Geography

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Unit 4 — Indian Polity & Constitution

4.1 Fundamental Rights · DPSPs · Panchayati Raj · Centre-State Relations	
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- 7.1 ISRO · Digital Agriculture · Precision Farming
- 7.2 Biotechnology: GMOs · Biofertilisers · Biopesticides
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Unit 8 — Environment & Ecology

- 8.1 Biodiversity · Western Ghats · Karnataka Species
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Appendices

- Appendix A — Rapid Revision Digest (All 80 Facts)
- Appendix B — Karnataka Schemes Master Table
- Appendix C — Important Acts Cheatsheet

UNIT 1 — CURRENT AFFAIRS

Karnataka · National · International | Tag:  **SAFE** ·  SKIP

Chapter at a Glance

	Details
Unit	1 of 8 Current Affairs
Estimated questions in exam	15–20 questions (Paper 1)
Exam strategy	Mostly safe to attempt; verify appointments 2 weeks before exam
Last-night revision	Re-read Section 6 (10 rapid-revision facts). Facts change yearly.
Field relevance	These schemes form the core operational mandate of an AO from Day 1 of posting.

Unit Overview

It is your third day as Agricultural Officer in Kalaburagi. A farmer named Shivappa walks into your office, dust on his feet, worry on his face. He has heard that the government gives money directly to farmers every four months — but he has not received anything yet. He shows you a printout someone gave him at a fair — it says 'PM-Kisan, Rs. 2,000 instalment.' But he does not know which bank account to register, whether he is eligible, or who to contact.

You are the only government officer he trusts enough to ask.

In that moment, every line of this chapter becomes relevant. The scheme name, the amount, the eligibility, the process — this is not General Studies. This is your job.

Most candidates preparing for general competitive examinations treat Current Affairs as a box to tick — read a newspaper, memorise a few facts, hope something appears in the exam. For the AO/AAO examination, however, Current Affairs carries a different weight. The schemes covered in this chapter are the same schemes that an Agricultural Officer implements, explains, and verifies from the very first day of field posting.

The examiner who sets this paper is also the person who frames the job description of an AO. When a question asks 'Under PM-Kisan, how many instalments are given per year?' — it is not testing memorisation alone. It is testing whether the officer being recruited can answer a farmer's question accurately and confidently.

□ **Agri Lens:** Every scheme in this unit — PM-Kisan, PMFBY, Soil Health Card, eNAM — is something an AO will explain to farmers, verify beneficiary lists for, and report implementation progress on. These topics are not General Knowledge. They are the operational mandate of the post.

This unit covers seven broad areas: Karnataka agri policy updates, central government schemes, international events, important appointments, awards, budget allocations, and — new in this edition — Karnataka GI Tags and APEDA. Each sub-topic opens with a conceptual explanation followed by facts in structured format. Mini checkpoints after each sub-topic reinforce key points. The practice questions section contains 27 exam-style questions with trap explanations. The rapid revision section provides 10 high-yield facts for last-day review.

A note on exam strategy. The negative marking in this examination is -0.75 per wrong answer. Each sub-topic in this chapter carries a small strategy note indicating whether a question on that topic is safe to attempt, should be attempted only with high certainty, or should be left unanswered. These strategy notes can protect marks as effectively as knowing one more fact.

Core Concepts

1.1 Karnataka Agricultural Policy Developments

Karnataka State Government: Agricultural Policy Landscape

The Karnataka state government directly shapes the agricultural environment in which an Agricultural Officer operates. Unlike central schemes, which are uniform across India, state schemes are tailored to Karnataka's specific soil types, crop patterns, and farmer demographics. The Agricultural Officer is the primary field-level implementation officer for these state schemes — and the examination tests preparedness for exactly that role.

The Siddaramaiah-led Karnataka government (elected 2023) made agriculture one of its focus areas, announcing the Five Guarantees (Pancha Shakthi) of which Raitha Bhagya specifically targets farmers. Understanding what changed — and what remains unchanged — is what this section is about.

KARNATAKA AGRICULTURE BUDGET 2025-26 — KEY HEADS	
Agriculture department (total)	Rs. 4,500+ crore — extension, inputs, infrastructure
Krishi Bhagya scheme	Rs. 800 crore — farm ponds, watershed, drip irrigation
Raitha Siri (PM-Kisan top-up)	Rs. 500 crore — premium subsidy for small farmers
PM-Kisan state supplement	Rs. 200 crore — additional support to beneficiaries
Bhoo Chethana (soil + water)	Rs. 300 crore — soil testing, water conservation

AO IN THE FIELD — Raitha Bhagya vs Rythu Bandhu Confusion

Farmer: Sir, my cousin in Telangana gets Rs. 10,000 per acre. But I am only getting Rs. 6,000 for my whole farm. Why?

AO: That is a different scheme in a different state. What your cousin receives is Telangana's Rythu Bandhu — it is calculated per acre. What you receive is PM-Kisan from the central government — it is Rs. 6,000 per year per farmer family, regardless of land size.

Farmer: So which is better?

AO: It depends. If you have 5 acres, Rythu Bandhu gives Rs. 50,000. PM-Kisan gives Rs. 6,000. But Rythu Bandhu is only for Telangana farmers. Karnataka has Raitha Siri as a top-up on PM-Kisan for small and marginal farmers.

⚠ Watch out: Do not confuse Karnataka's Raitha Bhagya with Telangana's Rythu Bandhu. They are different schemes with different amounts and different eligibility criteria. This is one of the most common traps in Karnataka PSC exams.

⇒ **QUICK CHECKPOINT**

1. Karnataka's Raitha Siri scheme functions as a _____ on top of PM-Kisan.
 2. Which Karnataka scheme focuses on farm pond construction and drip irrigation — Krishi Bhagya or Bhoo Chethana?
- (Answers are in the MCQ bank — Section 5)

1.2 Central Government Schemes Affecting Farmers

The Five Schemes Every AO Must Know Cold

The following five central schemes represent the backbone of agricultural welfare in India. They appear consistently in the examination and are equally relevant during field posting. The measure of preparation is not just whether a candidate recognises these scheme names — it is whether the concepts are understood well enough to explain them clearly to a farmer encountering them for the first time.

Scheme 1 — PM-Kisan: Direct Cash, No Conditions

Launched in December 2018, the Pradhan Mantri Kisan Samman Nidhi (PM-Kisan) is arguably the simplest agricultural welfare scheme India has ever run. The logic is elegantly straightforward: identify every landholder farmer family, transfer Rs. 6,000 directly into their bank account every year, in three instalments of Rs. 2,000 each, with no conditions on how they spend it.

This matters because before PM-Kisan, income support for farmers always came with strings attached — you had to buy a specific input, adopt a specific practice, or belong to a specific category. PM-Kisan removed all of that. The money goes directly from the government's account to the farmer's account — no middlemen, no conditions.

□ **PM-KISAN — COMPLETE SCHEME PROFILE**

Full name	Pradhan Mantri Kisan Samman Nidhi
Launched	December 2018
Annual amount	Rs. 6,000 per farmer family per year
Instalments	3 instalments of Rs. 2,000 each
Instalment schedule	April–July August–November December–March
Transfer mode	Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) — directly to bank
Eligibility	All landholder farmer families
Exclusions	Income tax payers, government employees, large farmers (state-defined)
Ministry	Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers' Welfare
Karnataka coverage	~50 lakh Karnataka farmers covered
Karnataka supplement	Raitha Siri provides top-up for small and marginal farmers

❑ **Here's the trick:** Exam questions often ask about the instalment amount (Rs. 2,000) rather than the annual amount (Rs. 6,000). Know both. Also remember: PM-Kisan was Rs. 6,000 from the very first instalment — it was never increased. Any option saying it was 'recently increased to Rs. 6,000' is wrong.

❑ **DID YOU KNOW?** PM-Kisan has transferred over Rs. 3.04 lakh crore to more than 11 crore farmer families since its launch — making it one of the largest direct benefit transfer programmes in the world. Karnataka alone has ~50 lakh beneficiary farmers.

Scheme 2 — PMFBY: Insuring the Farmer's Risk

Farming is inherently risky. A drought, a flood, an unseasonal hailstorm — any of these can wipe out an entire season's work and push a farmer into debt. The Pradhan Mantri Fasal Bima Yojana (PMFBY), launched in Kharif 2016, was designed to be the answer to this risk. It replaced the old National Agricultural Insurance Scheme (NAIS), which had high premiums and slow claim settlements.

The key innovation in PMFBY was two-fold: it capped the farmer's premium at a low percentage (maximum 2% for Kharif crops), and it brought in technology — satellite imagery and drone surveys — to assess crop damage faster and more objectively than the old committee-based method.

□ PMFBY — COMPLETE SCHEME PROFILE	
Full name	Pradhan Mantri Fasal Bima Yojana
Launched	Kharif 2016
Replaced	NAIS (National Agricultural Insurance Scheme, 1999)
Farmer premium — Kharif	Maximum 2% of sum insured
Farmer premium — Rabi	Maximum 1.5% of sum insured
Farmer premium — Horticulture	Maximum 5% of sum insured
Rest of premium	Shared equally by Centre and State governments
Coverage period	Pre-sowing to post-harvest (14 days after harvest)
Claim technology	Satellite remote sensing + drone surveys
Karnataka link	State government pays 50% of remaining premium; Raitha Suraksha supplements

Feature	Old NAIS (1999)	New PMFBY (2016)
Farmer premium (Kharif)	2.5–3.5%	Maximum 2%
Claim assessment method	Village-level committee	Satellite + drone technology
Settlement speed	Months to years	Target: within 2 months
Coverage	Limited crops	Most crops including horticulture
Karnataka supplement	Not available	Raitha Suraksha top-up

⚠ **Watch out:** PMFBY uses the word 'maximum' for farmer premium — the actual premium charged can be lower than 2%.

Many exam questions try to trick you into saying the farmer always pays exactly 2%. The word 'maximum' is the key. Also note: Rabi premium is 1.5%, not 2% — the season matters.

□ **AO IN THE FIELD — Explaining PMFBY to a Skeptical Farmer**

Farmer: I paid crop insurance last year and got nothing when my ragi failed. Why should I pay again?

AO: I understand your frustration. Which scheme were you enrolled in?

Farmer: I don't know. The bank made me pay.

AO: Under PMFBY — the scheme running now — if your crop fails due to drought, flood, or pest attack, the damage is assessed using drone surveys and satellite images. You don't wait for a committee to visit your field. And your premium is a maximum of 2% for Kharif crops. The rest is paid by the government.

Farmer: How long does it take to get the money?

AO: The target is within 60 days of claim submission. The old system took much longer — that was the problem with the previous insurance scheme.

⇒ **QUICK CHECKPOINT**

1. PMFBY replaced which earlier crop insurance scheme?
2. What technology does PMFBY use for claim assessment that the old NAIS did not?

(Answers are in the MCQ bank — Section 5)

Scheme 3 — Soil Health Card: Knowing Your Field Before Spending on It

Here is a fact that surprises most people: the majority of Indian farmers apply fertilisers without ever testing their soil. They follow their neighbours' practice, or the input dealer's recommendation, or simply what their father did. The result is often over-application of some nutrients and deficiency of others — wasting money and damaging soil health over time.

The Soil Health Card scheme, launched on 19 February 2015 by Prime Minister Modi in Suratgarh, Rajasthan, was designed to change this. The idea is simple: test every farmer's soil every two years, hand them a card that tells them exactly what nutrients their soil has and lacks, and recommend the precise fertiliser dose for their next three crops.

			which category in the question
World Food Prize	World Food Prize Foundation	Global contribution to food security	Called 'Nobel of Food' — NOT given by Nobel Committee
Padma Shri / Bhushan	Govt of India	Contribution across all fields including agriculture	Subhash Palekar received Padma Shri 2016 for ZBNF

❑ **Here's the trick:** The World Food Prize is universally called 'the Nobel Prize for Food and Agriculture.' The trap: it is NOT given by the Nobel Committee. It is given by the World Food Prize Foundation. A Nobel Prize for Agriculture simply does not exist. If you see 'Nobel Prize for Agriculture' as an answer option — it is always wrong.

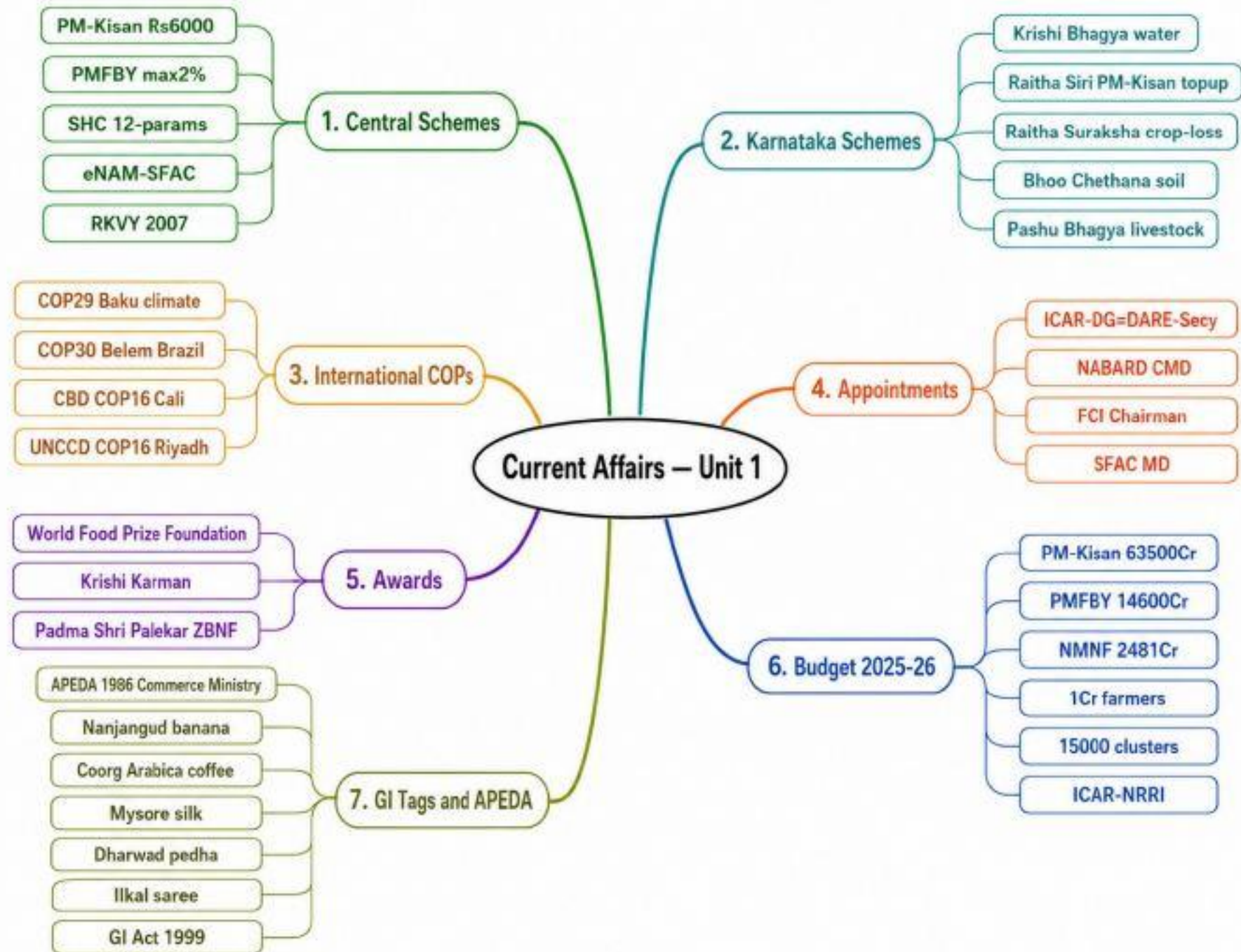
Zero Budget Natural Farming (ZBNF) — promoted by Subhash Palekar and officially adopted by Karnataka — is a farming system where the farmer does not spend any money on external inputs. All inputs come from on-farm resources: cow dung, cow urine, local plants, and fermentation products. Karnataka adopted this approach because chemical input costs had become the single largest burden on small farmers.

❑ **DID YOU KNOW?** Subhash Palekar's ZBNF has four core components: (1) Beejamrit — seed treatment with cow-dung water; (2) Jiwamrit — soil inoculant made from cow dung, cow urine, jaggery, and pulse flour; (3) Mulching — covering soil with crop residue; (4) Waaphasa — maintaining soil moisture-air balance. Karnataka's agricultural extension programmes now teach these four components to farmers. Expect 1 MCQ testing the component names vs their functions.

⇒ QUICK CHECKPOINT

1. The World Food Prize is awarded by the Nobel Committee — True or False?

Mind Map



Zone 8	Hilly Zone	Kodagu, Chikkamagaluru, Shivamogga (W), Hassan (W)	1500–3000 mm	Laterite (Ultisol)	Coffee, cardamom, pepper, arecanut, paddy
Zone 9	Coastal Zone	Dakshina Kannada, Udupi, Uttara Kannada (coastal)	3000–4500 mm	Coastal laterite, alluvial	Paddy, coconut, arecanut, banana, cashew
Zone 10	North-Western Zone	Belagavi, Bagalkot (SW), Uttara Kannada (eastern ghats)	600–1200 mm	Black + red mixed	Sugarcane, jowar, cotton, paddy

□ **Here's the trick:** For exam: Karnataka = 10 agro-climatic zones (state classification). India = 15 zones (Planning Commission national classification). Karnataka falls in National Zone V (Southern Plateau and Hills). Zone 1 = driest (tur dal, jowar). Zone 9 = wettest (paddy, coconut). An exam question asking 'how many agro-climatic zones in Karnataka' = 10.

□ **DID YOU KNOW?** Karnataka's 10-zone classification was developed jointly by the Department of Agriculture, Karnataka, ICAR Regional Station (Bengaluru), and the University of Agricultural Sciences. The zones are used in designing the state's Annual Action Plan for Agriculture — each zone receives specific variety recommendations, target crop areas, and subsidy allocations based on its agro-climatic profile. An AO's posting order specifies the zone and sub-zone for administrative identification.

□ **Agri Lens:** When an Agricultural Officer is transferred to a new district, the first reference document is the Agro-Climatic Zone profile for that zone — it summarises the soil health data, average rainfall, cropping pattern, major schemes active in the zone, and recommended crop varieties for all major crops. Understanding the zone profile is the fastest way for a new AO to become operationally competent.

□ **AO IN THE FIELD — Zone-Based Variety Recommendation —**